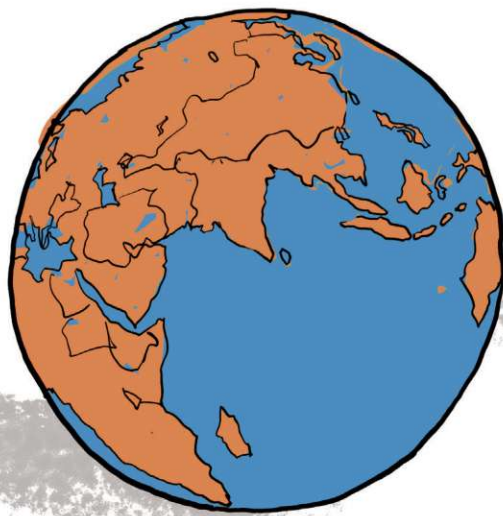




After 60: A new world

A government-mandated retirement age may mark the end of a formal working life, but across urban India, seniors are saying a firm no to the idea of stopping, choosing instead to work, learn, teach, travel and reinvent themselves, discovers **Drishti Rakhra**

DH Illustration: **Deepak Harichandan**



A friend's 70-plus father often finds himself called to manage the land he owns in Kerala. This call comes not from an external voice, but from within. He's always moving, finding things to do, and when the need arises, he also sues people for doing something they shouldn't, like encroaching on his land. My friend laughs each time she describes a new person he is suing.

This 70-year-old busybody is just one of many in a demographic of older people, senior citizens, if you will, who find themselves working after the government-mandated retirement age. There is a considerable shift in the trend, visible in the endless list of resources available for senior citizens, that allows people to work post-60.

Search for something beyond

Durga Pathak, who is only two years younger than the country's independence, began thinking about what he wanted to do post-retirement 14 months before D-day arrived. He thought about the time he had spent and "what really gave him joy" in his long and dynamic career. He worked as a consultant in a corporate firm based in Jamshedpur and went wherever his company sent him. He particularly remembered a stretch when he conducted training sessions for corporates, so that's what he decided to do. His long career gave him the option to ask himself a question he didn't have time for before: what did he want to do? One's time after retirement belongs to no one but oneself. At this stage in life, there's no concern for money, but a search for something beyond the structure of regular life, he feels.

Durga, who has lived through a corporate culture where women were being hired just to tick off a box, now finds that hiring trends among young people are changing. More women are joining the workforce, but more people are also leaving quickly. "The amount of churn that's happening with the younger generation was not there earlier, because children don't know what they want out of their work, you know?" Attrition rates are high, and people move jobs quickly. Someone as senior as him then becomes key to an organisation that is trying to maintain some

semblance of stability.

Value-added services

Value is the parameter used to measure whether one should continue to remain in the workplace. When corporates know that someone is key to the firm, Durga says that "they are retained till the ages of 60-70." Similar experiences are clear across professions, be it a professor at a college or a stenographer working for a solicitor.

Vijaya (*name changed*) is well into her seventies, but spends every day at the chambers of a real estate 'solicitor' whom she has worked for all her life. For someone in her role, retirement is flexible, but when the pandemic hit, she was confined to her house. She spent her days with family, completing household chores and getting used to a life of no work. But when the chance presented itself and her then-former boss called her back, she jumped at the chance. Now, she works from 11 am to 6 pm every day, and goes to the office in a cab that picks her up from home. She's certain, though, that she's only there because she's contributing to the office; there's no unnecessary sympathy from anyone.

She works with younger colleagues who are "quick with projectors" and good with computers. She became a typist when typewriters were tools of the trade, and has now learned to use the desktop, which she describes as "fairly simple" when compared to all that "artificial intelligence and all." She usually gets help from members of the team, and strongly believes that learning is lifelong, as long as one chooses to do it.

The AI impact

Working conditions are naturally impacted by technology. The AI boom, as one might expect, continues to cause ripples in this section of society, and no one is unaware. Durga Pathak describes the work done by AI as "donkey work," so whatever else may change, the real work that humans must do continues to remain ours. While there is a demand to learn how to use AI tools in all kinds of work, there is also something to be said about years of invaluable experience that cannot be quantified. This statement is echoed across professions, and especially rings true in the education sector.

Dr Etienne Rassendren, a senior research professor at St Joseph's University, Bengaluru, describes his relationship with learning that allows him to continue teaching even post-retirement. After he retired in 2020, he graduated to part-time teaching and moved to the PhD wing of the university. He chooses to work four days a week now, and spends about 4-6 hours a day on campus, as opposed to the regular seven hours that faculty members are required to clock in. "My friends laugh at me," he says, "This is basically a full-time role."

But this is also what he wants. His time now belongs to him, and especially when one is not working for money or towards a materialistic goal, the day frees up to create room for joy and passion. He adds, "There's some internal sense that makes you feel that you still have not completed the task that has been set out for you." The search for purpose is an ongoing quest, and the journey ends only when one wants it to. He describes it as an "internal self-expectation."

Packed schedules

Nidhi Chawla, who runs a pan-Indian community-building group, Silver Talkies, describes a similar need for purpose beyond a certain age. While this quest does not always result in people seeking out paid work, there is a desire for community among senior people that demands attention.

Silver Talkies was first started in Bengaluru and has now expanded to several other cities, including Pune, Kolkata and Delhi. Nidhi, who started the forum four years ago, says, "The idea germinated from observations at home." When her father retired, she assumed that he would have ample free time to pursue hobbies and use his time in whatever way he liked. Her retirement gift to him then was art supplies, but while he "dabbled in these for 3-4 months, he [then] gave it all up, and that brought to [her] understanding how community and external motivation is needed for you to continue to do what you really love." And workplaces often give people exactly this.

Jyothi, who is a part of another social group for seniors called Seenagers, describes a similar impulse. "Most of us get together at least monthly." Their schedules are packed with temple visits, travel

plans and movies they watch regularly. The group is full of people who have retired and whose children don't live in the same city.

Recently, the Seenager group organised a dance programme at Malleswaram Club, through one of the seniors who has a membership there. Right from planning the event, managing invites and choreographing the dance, the entire evening was planned by members of the group.

In a similar vein, Silver Talkies organises their yearly visit to Kolkata for Durga Puja without fail. Care is taken to make sure that the trip is not physically demanding, and walking is limited, but the trip is a headline, something everyone looks forward to.

Members are often requesting in-person meet-ups and more trips, but these are not always the easiest to manage because everyone is lodged in different parts of the country.

Brand-new careers

While such activities are challenging on their own, Chawla describes a host of seniors who have taken on brand-new careers "in their second innings." From knitting to modelling and acting, teaching and even doing master's degrees after 'retiring', this newfound freedom allows them to reimagine their hobbies and transform these into jobs.

Padmaja Duvvuri, who is 60, is a part of Silver Talkies. An HR professional, she retired from a watch company a couple of years ago and immediately picked up the one thing that she enjoyed the most about her work: helping people improve their lives. As she was ready to retire, she knew that she "needed something solid to do." Padmaja describes herself as a 'workaholic', and has always found meaning in work. Why should that continue based on a government-mandated age? So she did a two-year master's in counselling and family therapy from IGNOU.

The classroom was challenging, in a good way. It occupied her entire day and forced her to read and gain new knowledge in a way that a working life doesn't completely allow one to do. She just wanted to learn.

She describes her experience during an internship in a well-being centre: "So I used to ask questions, put my hand up for everything and I didn't give a damn about

what they thought, you know? I think some of them were amused, some of them were irritated. Some of them were probably a little impressed."

She learned as much about them as they learned about her. These relationships in the classroom eventually grew into friendships, simply by proximity. She doesn't meet them often now that the course is over and they all have such different lives, but they end up meeting for a coffee or a meal every once in a while.

As a mental health professional now, she holds various titles. From doing training sessions for corporates to conducting therapy sessions, she finds that she is able to manage her time in the way she wants. Sometimes, she has to remind herself that she doesn't necessarily have to do yoga in the morning, and can even get to it later in the day. A full, working life has taught her habits that don't always serve her.

Now and then, she takes herself out for a coffee, a visit to a bookstore on Church Street, or even for a film. Her time is her own.

Second innings

After a certain age, time is defined not by responsibility but by a kind of desire to use this time well, to allow one to search for meaning in life. The "second innings" that Nidhi Chawla describes is not one marked by economic necessity but a changing economy that has made room for individuals once thought to be 'retired'.

The internet is rife with content creators, both young and old, urging audiences to rethink when one must retire. It can be much before you are 60, or much after. Retirement age, depending on professions, is increasing gradually. Doctors and lawyers find themselves staying on the job beyond the mandated age.

The Andhra Pradesh government recently formed a committee to evaluate the current retirement age in the public sector. What was once written in stone is now somewhat shaky. The new proposal suggests pushing the age to 62, to evaluate "the financial implications, [and] working conditions of the employees," according to a recent newspaper report. There's also a yearly job fair for senior citizens held in Bengaluru; work specific to seniors is available everywhere, from operations to data collection and management jobs.

MIXED BAG

From the battlefield to the classroom

As an officer with the Assam Rifles posted in the hills of Mizoram in 2003, Christopher Rego's focus was not only on tackling militants but also on understanding the factors that pushed young people towards militancy.

A Bengaluru resident, Rego and his wife, Myrna, soon realised that the roots of militancy were not merely ideological, but also linked to limited access to education and employment. Visits to villages around Aizawl, Mizoram's capital, showed them how young people were being drawn into militant groups and drug trafficking, partly because of a lack of educational opportunities and mentoring.

Rego and his wife began sponsoring a few underprivileged children with their own money. "Soon, we witnessed how small help transformed their



Christopher Rego (centre) with members of the Sunbird Trust.

lives and bridged the trust deficit with the security forces," Rego, who retired as a Colonel in 2016, told *DHoS* in Imphal, Manipur. With him sat a small group of young students and professionals whom Sunbird Trust, a charitable organisation founded by Rego in 2014, had helped by sponsoring their education. "It was because of Sunbird Trust that I could realise my dream of becoming a lawyer," said Stephen P, a lawyer practising in the Manipur High Court. A Naga from Chingmei Khullen village in Naga-dominated Senapati district, Stephen was spon-

sored by the trust for his LLB in Bengaluru and subsequently for an LLM at Chandigarh University.

"My parents were unable to pay for higher education. If Sunbird Trust had not supported my education and stay, I am not sure where I would be today," he said.

In 2012, when Rego was posted in Manipur as an officer with the Border Roads Organisation (BRO), a visit to Ljeirong village in Noney district gave him another compelling reason to dedicate his life to children and young people in the militancy-hit Northeast.

"I was moved by five or six school-children cooking on their own because their parents were away at work. I realised that these children needed a hostel. A brigadier in the Assam Rifles responded positively to our call for help. The villagers joined our efforts by providing land and labour, and we soon constructed the hostel."

Since then, Sunbird Trust and its team have transformed the lives of thousands of school and college stu-

dents across Manipur, Assam, Arunachal Pradesh, Meghalaya and Mizoram. Many have gone on to become doctors, engineers, lawyers, teachers and entrepreneurs.

"We help by directly sponsoring underprivileged students based on their needs and also support schools by constructing libraries, hostels and classrooms," Rego said. "We assist irrespective of religion, caste or community and help students impacted by the ongoing conflict that started in May 2023." Ronia Haobijam, a young Meitei woman who is now a teacher in Moirang, in Meitei-dominated Bishnupur district, said the sponsorship changed her life. "It is because of the sponsorship that I could complete my graduation and become a teacher," she said. Rego said more than 63,000 students have been assisted since 2014, with 14,000 currently receiving sponsorship across the Northeast.

"The greatest satisfaction after more than a decade of work is seeing numerous Sunbird youngsters cross

the threshold to employment, become self-sufficient and even pull entire families out of poverty," he said. "It is even more gratifying when they return as full-fledged team members of Sunbird Trust and help other students." He recalled the son of a vegetable vendor whom the trust supported and who now works in the US. "He sent us back the amount we spent on his education so that we can help others like him in the Northeast," Rego said. Sunbird Trust now has 92 partner schools, 69 of them in Manipur. The organisation has also supported students and communities during the 2016 earthquake in Manipur, the pandemic, including by providing food and shelter in places such as Bengaluru, and the ongoing conflict since 2023. Rego's team has continued working in highly conflict-affected areas despite uncertain security conditions. Convincing funding agencies that children needed support was another challenge.

SUMIR KARMAKAR, DHNS

'Mixed Bag' is your Sunday potpourri — an assortment of snappy articles, engaging ideas and snackable nibbles about this and that, from here and there. Dip in!



FEEDBACK
Like this story? Write to us at dhonsunday@deccanherald.co.in



ASTROSPEAK

Guruji Shrii Arnav



Scan the QR code to read the weekly horoscope